



FLYING HIGH:
Babu at a
kite-making
session

The Quaint Alchemist

Thirty-one and still counting, a metallurgist does quirky things all for the sake of records

■ **By Stephen David**

Flying as many paper planes as possible in an hour and cutting cucumber into millions of tiny pieces may not be everybody's idea of having fun. For 51-year-old S. Ramesh Babu, a doctorate in metallurgy and a teacher at the Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore, it is not just fun but a passion. This passion has also earned him a unique distinction—that of the only Indian in the *Guinness Book of World Records* with over 30 feats to his credit. Though he is still a long way from either of them, Babu's role models in eccentric distinctions are Ashrita Furman of the US and Terry Cole of the UK, both of whom hold about 200 world records each. When not winding threads, flying frisbees or making kites at break-neck speed, Babu works on mathematical models and devises ways to economise on steel-making. Here too, he has four patents and over 60 published papers and reports to his credit.

"It is the right mix of physical and mental endurance which helps one turn the impossible into possible," he says, referring to his record-breaking feat in February 1994



when he managed to toss the table tennis ball uninterrupted, alternatively on both sides of the bat (without changing the position of the feet) 9,900 times in one hour, five minutes and 40 seconds. Ferocious in his pursuit of peculiar records, Babu successfully attempted two more in March this year—fastest skipping in a minute and fastest manual threading—which took his score to 31.

For the quirky genius "whose mind is constantly whirring with ideas", breaking and creating records does not simply mean collecting certificates and some publicity. Through this quest, he hopes "to inspire others to connect with their indomitable inner strength". Little wonder then that he runs Top of the World, a motivation centre where he trains people to help them realise their hidden potential.

Persistent in his endeavours, Babu says he will keep pushing himself to the limits to achieve more. "I don't even think of what I have done, I am focused on what is still undone," he says. And who knows while you are reading this piece, this man may be gearing up to do something interesting, just for the records' sake. ■